Notes: Jane Austen, Life and Times

Basic Facts

- Born December 16, 1775, in Steventon, England
- Died July 18, 1817, in Winchester, England (age 41)

Early Life

- Grew up in a large, middle-class family
- Father (George) was a clergyman who encouraged his kids to love learning
- Mother (Cassandra) was quick-witted and liked telling stories
- Youngest of eight children: six brothers and one sister
    - Sister Cassandra was her close companion her whole life

Middle Life

- Never married, but had at least two suitors
- Age 20: romance with Tom Lefroy (Irish)
    - Neither of them had money, so marrying would have been unwise
- Age 27: accepted a proposal from Harris Bigg-Wither (a well-off friend), then changed her mind the next morning

Later Life

- Lived with different family members and stayed with her brothers for long visits
- 1801: moved to Bath with her parents and Cassandra
- 1805: father died, and she moved to Southampton
- 1809: moved to a cottage her brother provided
- 1817: taken to Winchester to be cared for by a surgeon, died July 18
- Modern scholars think she died of Addison's disease

Publication History

- Wrote six novels and was working on a seventh when she died
- 1811: Sense and Sensibility
- 1813: Pride and Prejudice (became a bestseller)
- 1814: Mansfield Park
- 1815: Emma

- 1817: Northanger Abbey and Persuasion (published after she died)
- 1817: started Sanditon, never finished

A Writer for Women Alone?

- Her books focus on characters' home/domestic lives
- Every published novel has a marriage plot
- Main characters are always women
- Barely mentions the big events of her time (like wars)

Satire

- Satire = using humor, irony, exaggeration, or ridicule to expose and criticize foolishness or vices
- Social satire = using humor to criticize people and political systems
- Austen's novels are social satires: she pokes fun at and critiques the society she lived in

What Austen Was Critiquing

1. Marriage

- Women were expected to marry
- Marrying for love was becoming more popular, but not everyone could
- Money was the biggest factor for most people
- Families arranged good (advantageous) marriages for their kids
- Daughters got a dowry to attract suitable men
- Women depended on men for money
    - Few ways for women to earn money
    - Middle-class women could be governesses, but it was not a great job
    - Married women could not work outside the home unless the marriage contract allowed it
- Marrying outside your social class was frowned upon
- Rich men sometimes had lower-class mistresses but did not admit it publicly
- Women who married into a higher class were looked down on by their new peers
- My prediction: Austen probably criticized marrying for money/status instead of love, and how few choices women had

2. Social Class

- The English class system was rigid

- Three main classes:
    - Upper class: lived mostly in leisure, made money from investments (about 4% a year)
    - Middle class: merchants, lawyers, clergy, and people who owned some land
    - Lower class: tenant farmers and manual laborers
- Hard to move between classes, and lots of resentment between them
- My prediction: she probably mocked snobby upper-class people and judging others by class/wealth

3. Clergy and the Church

- Religion was a big part of daily life
- Rectors were appointed to "livings" as heads of local churches
- Livings were often given to family, friends, or acquaintances of whoever funded the position
- Most rectors did not feel a religious calling; they just wanted a stable, respectable middle-class job
- Younger sons of upper-class families also joined the church
- My prediction: she probably poked fun at clergymen who cared more about money and status than faith

4. War and England

- England was at war almost constantly during her life
- American Revolution (1775-1783), Napoleonic Wars (1803-1815), War of 1812, and others, so many young men were away fighting
- Up to 20,000 killed every year of the Napoleonic Wars
- People in England feared a French invasion
- My prediction: she may have hinted at how war affected families and the officers (soldiers/navy men) who show up in her books